Angel of Philadelphia

By Allen Amundsen

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INTRODUCTION

"I have a dream that one day this nation will rise up and live out the true meaning of its creed: 'We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal.'" At the height of the Civil Rights Movement in 1963, these famous words were spoken from the steps of the Lincoln Memorial in Washington, D.C..

But Martin Luther King, Jr., was not the first to raise his voice from those steps with a message of hope for America's future. That distinction belongs to the world-famous contralto Marian Anderson, whose performance at the Lincoln Memorial on April 9, 1939, made a compelling case for the transformative power of music, and in a place typically associated with the power of words.

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MARIAN: If someone would have told me that some day, I would be singing if front of *seventy-five thousand faces . . .* I would have called 'em crazy. "Get out now. You're out of your mind!" But there I was, standing at the top of the steps of the Lincoln Memorial, the giant white marble statue of 'ol honest Abe himself looking down on me. I just knew any minute; someone would shout at me and ask me to leave. "*What's that colored girl think she's doing?"* But no one shouted. No one yelled. No one called me awful names. Only my voice: my instrument from God himself remained. And I sang with all of my heart that night.

(Sing opening lyrics of "MY COUNTRY TIS OF THEE")

TRANSITION

There was nothing overtly political in the selection of songs Anderson performed that day before a gathered crowd of 75,000 and a live radio audience of millions. But the message inherent in an African American woman singing "My Country 'Tis of Thee" while standing before the shrine of America's Great Emancipator was crystal clear.

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MARIAN: I'm a Philly Girl. South Philadelphia to be exact--born and raised. Philly is known as the birthplace of freedom, the City of Brotherly love…well, when I was growing up, it was those things in name only. Every day, I felt this presence. I call it, The Glare. People, they had this stare, this gaze—it burrows into your skin. It hurts, sometimes, like tiny daggers cutting you down, piece by piece.

My mama and daddy did everything they could to shield us from hate. They did this by taking us to church. People often ask me how I found music…and I think back on it, and I really feel that it was music that found me!

God had a plan for me. I discovered my voice while singing in church. I was asked to be a member of the choir; then they wanted me to be a soloist; and then some of the older folks in the church insisted that I take my gift and go to music school. The congregation even took up a collection for me to pay for it! With their graciousness in my hand, I went downtown Philadelphia to one of the biggest and best music schools in the state. I walked into the Admissions office excited and hopeful. As I closed the door, all noises stopped—typewriters, conversations, even the phone seemed to quit ringing. There was a young blonde woman at the main reception desk. She had to have been at least twenty-one or twenty-two. Instantly I saw it in her eyes: The Glare. The tiny daggers, the non-verbal accusation: *what are you doing here huh? What do YOU want colored girl?* I politely walked up to her and asked about the application process. Her milky white face had turned pink and she wouldn't look at me! Not once. I asked again, "How do I apply for the vocalist program?" She didn't say anything except for sorry. We just don't have room. *Room for a black girl!* I thought angrily to myself. I almost gave up…I almost let it crush my dreams. When God plants a dream in your mind, it's hard to shake it off. I eventually found a teacher, the most famous teacher in Philadelphia, Giuseppe Boghetti. Giuseppe helped me hone my instrument and move my voice to higher plains. He

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said that a voice like mine came once in a *thousand years,* and that my contralto was from heaven. The Angel of Philadelphia. That's what he called me.

Well, this Angel has flown everywhere, from New York City to Moscow. I even had fans! If someone would have told me, "Marian…girl, you're going to be famous one day! Men and women all around the world will pay money just to hear you sing…" I would've told them they were crazy. But that's what happened. The music found me. In spite of all of that---the traveling, the concerts, the audiences, the applause and admiration… the Glare never went away. The hateful stares, the cold gaze of white folks cut into me everywhere I went.

And I had some notoriety by the time I came back from my tour of Europe. I'll tell ya---Europe and America may be on different sides of the world, but they may as well be on different planets. In Europe, I never heard colored girl go home or had the n-word flippantly tossed at me; and I never saw The Glare. The Glare had gone away when I was in Europe. Only smiles, applause, and respect.

And then I come back to the states, this separate reality, this---this divided paradise where if you were black you're nothing. I remember walking into the Continental in the Upper East Side. Walking in, I thought: this is New York. This is a well known hotel. There shouldn't be any problems. The front desk clerk looked up from the check-in desk and did a double take. I watched him closely as he fumbled with his little box of reservation cards. The young man cleared his throat and told me he couldn't find my reservation. He added they were completely booked. Sorry.

I had the honor of being invited to sing at Constitution Hall. I could not believe it. That room had special spirit to it--- freedom, inspiration, creativity, possibility. What a thrill it was…the first African American to perform there!

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I went to meet a few key members of the Daughters of American Revolution, who owned the building. I stepped through the main foyer and into the events office. As soon as I set foot into the room… silence.

I explained that I was Marian Anderson and that I was scheduled to perform there in a few days. Their eyes were in shock, mouths agape, not understanding. I asked to speak with the director, but no, she wasn't there and could you leave a telephone number or we'll telegram you, blah, blah, blah. I was quickly rushed out. I did receive a phone call…canceling my show at Constitution Hall. They had a strict policy: no Negroes were allowed to perform. The Daughters of American Revolution had rules. And they excluded black people. Some revolution huh?

Back at the hotel the phone rang again. It was Eleanor Roosevelt. *The* Eleanor Roosevelt! The first lady! She adored my voice, she said. She was furious at the Daughters of American Revolution, she said. She resigned her membership to that group. She was determined to make things right. She wanted all of New England to hear me sing. And here I am. Easter Sunday, 1939. Standing at the steps of the Lincoln Memorial, the gigantic marble statue of ol Honest Abe staring down at me. I turned to look at his face, and I didn't see The Glare cutting into me…I saw I nod of approval. I think if that statue of Lincoln could've smiled, he would have! I glanced back at the thousands and thousands of faces gazing at me. The Glare wasn't there either. Only wide eyes, smiles, and joy.

If someone would've told me that some day, I would be singing in front of 75,000 people, I would of called 'em crazy. But there I was. And the Glare was gone. Maybe forever. I closed my eyes and I sang… my voice, my gift from God, pierced the sky, the clouds, The Angel of Philadelphia had flown.

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